

VOID DISPATCH

Various

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CITIES THAT NEVER SLEEP

Dana Ferris



There is a version of the 24-hour city that is glamorous. Jazz clubs. Diners. The last bus home

and someone interesting on it. That version existed, briefly, in a handful of places, and it was good.

The version we have now is different. It is **logistics**. It is a warehouse that cannot go dark because the sortation algorithm runs continuously and the humans inside it are cheaper than the reconfiguration cost of stopping.

The romantic 24-hour city was organized around desire. Someone wanted to be there at 3am. The logistical 24-hour city is organized around throughput. No one wants to be there. They are there because the model requires it.

The lights are always on here. That used to mean something.

— Outside a fulfillment center, 3:14am

This is the distinction that city planners, when they invoke "vibrancy," consistently fail to make. Vibrancy is not a property of illuminated windows. It is a property of people choosing to be somewhere.

We built infrastructure for the night and called it nightlife. We built coverage for every hour and called it community. We lit every corner and called it safety. None of these substitutions are neutral.

NOTE A city that cannot sleep is not awake. It is running a process.

THREE WAYS TO DISAPPEAR

M. Okafor



This is not a paranoia piece. This is a practice piece. Paranoia assumes a specific adversary. Practice assumes a general condition and responds proportionally.

Method one: go analog for the boring stuff. Most surveillance is passive and opportunistic. It collects whatever flows through the pipes. A notebook does not have a privacy policy. A pocket calendar does not sync to a data broker.

Method two: reduce identity surface area. You have more accounts than you need. Some are attached to your real name, phone number, a payment method, a device fingerprint. The reduction is not deactivation. It is to stop creating new ones.

Method three: make boring choices visible. Notice when you are making a choice. Not every choice requires a different decision. But many defaults were set by someone whose interests are not yours.

The Actual Threat Model

CAUTION

You are probably not being targeted specifically. You are in a database being queried by systems with no opinion about you as a person. The goal is not to escape the database. The goal is to make the query less useful.

THE LAST PAYPHONE

T. Nakamura



A photo essay without photos, because we lost the memory card.

The payphone on Delancey and Essex was removed in 2019. There is a LinkNYC kiosk there now. The kiosk offers free calls, fast Wi-Fi, and a screen that displays advertisements. It also collects device identifiers from passing phones.

The payphone offered free emergency calls and required a quarter for everything else. It collected nothing. It remembered nothing. When you hung up, the conversation was over.

You could call anyone and they couldn't call you back
unless they already knew where you were.

– A person who remembered the quarter

The last payphone in New York City was removed from a hotel lobby in 2022. It is now in a museum. Which is the correct place for things that society has decided it no longer needs, and which is also the correct place to go to feel the specific grief of infrastructure loss. The payphone knew nothing. That was the whole point.

SMALL GRID THEORY

S. Reyes



The most livable neighborhoods in most cities share one physical characteristic that urban planners consistently undervalue: **small blocks**. Not "walkable" in the sense of having sidewalks. Not "mixed-use" in the sense of having a Starbucks on the ground floor of a condo tower. Small blocks. Short distances between intersections. Many choices per square mile. The reason small blocks win is not aesthetic. It is combinatorial. A grid of small blocks offers exponentially more route choices than a grid of large blocks covering the same area.

NOTE Density is not the variable. Granularity is the variable.

The blocks have to be small first. Everything else follows from the blocks. Jane Jacobs said this in 1961. We have spent sixty years building the opposite.

THE MAINTENANCE WORKERS

P. Voss



Every city has two kinds of workers. The ones you see and the ones who make it possible for you

to see them. The street-level economy – cafés, shops, deliveries – depends on a substrate that is mostly invisible: the people who fix the pipes, patch the road, swap the transformer, re-hang the signal.

They work at 2am because the work cannot happen when the city is using itself. The road has to be empty. The water main has to be isolated. The substation has to be de-energized.

Invisibility as Success Metric

CAUTION

The KPI for infrastructure maintenance is the absence of events. Nothing happened. That is the goal. That is how you know it worked.

We have built an economy around visibility – metrics, dashboards, likes, impressions. And then we have built the physical world on top of people whose best outcome is that you never think about them at all.

THE SIGNAL LAYER

P. Voss



Every city runs on a layer you cannot see. Not the pipes, not the wires – those are findable, mappable, orange-flagged before you dig. The signal layer is different. It is the mesh of transmissions that tells the traffic light what the car did three blocks away.

The signal layer is where the city becomes legible to itself. Without it, the buses are just buses. With it, the buses are a dataset. The streets are a dataset. The pedestrians are a dataset.

What the Signal Layer Knows

CAUTION

Where you were. How fast you moved. What device you carried. Whether you stopped. For how long. Whether you stopped at that spot before.

The signal layer does not forget. The buses forget. The people forget. The signal layer keeps a log.

LETTERS

On the Bus Piece (Issue 02)

CAUTION

You said the bus is slow because of choices, not physics. I've been thinking about this for three weeks. You're right and I hate it. – J.W., Chicago

Correction

CAUTION

The Houston light rail does not go to the airport. We stated that it did. It does not. We regret this. – the editors

Submissions

CAUTION

800 words or fewer. No pitches. Send it done. Plaintext. – void-dispatch@proton.me

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